

Seminar # 7:

FAITH

Faith is absolute confidence in the *Person of God* and in what *He says He will do*. Faith in God through the work of salvation of Jesus Christ brings us into the love relationship with God called salvation. In that relationship, faith is the confidence that what God has promised or said will come to pass. Faith is based on God's power, not on human potential.

I. WHAT IS FAITH?

"Now faith is the substance of things hoped for and evidence of things not seen. (Hebrews 11:1)

Within the Scriptures, there are two distinct features of faith. (Romans 10:17)

- Faith always directly originates from God's Word.
- Faith is directly related to God's Word.

A. Scriptural pattern of faith (Rom. 4:17-21)

If we long for the faith that rises *above* the level of our physical senses *to* the realm of God's unchanging truth, then we have the Scriptures to provide us with the pattern for faith. And true scriptural faith consists of acting like Abraham and proceeding on his steps of faith (v. 11).

Abraham's Three Successful Steps of Faith:

1. ***He accepted God's promise as true.*** (v. 17)
2. ***He refused to accept the testimony of his senses.*** The testimony of his senses undoubtedly was that it was no longer possible for either of them to have a child. (vv. 18-19)
3. ***He held fast to what God had promised.*** (vv. 20-21) And because Abraham held fast to what God had promised, his physical experience and the testimony of his senses were brought in line with the testimony of God.

It is clearly shown here that the object upon which Abraham's faith is focused is God's Word. Thus, faith is based on the stated promises of God, only accepting the testimony of the senses in so far as they agree with God's Word.

B. Distinction between faith and hope

Hope is directed towards the future and is primarily in the realm of the mind.

It is an attitude of expectancy concerning things that are still in the future. It is a mental attitude of aspiration concerning the future.

Faith, on the other hand, is primarily in the realm of the heart. It is a condition of the heart that produces, here and now, something so real within us, that it can be described by the word of substance.

1 Thessalonians 5:8 further differentiates hope and faith. Hope is associated to a helmet, within the region of the head, that is, within the region of the mind. On the other hand, faith is found in the region of the breast, that is, in the region of the heart. This difference is further reinforced in Romans 10:10, where the exercise of faith, or believing, is directly associated with the heart.

C. Contrast between faith and sight [and other senses] (1Corinthians 5:7)

Sight and all other physical senses are related to the object of the physical and material world. All knowledge that comes to natural man comes to him through the five senses.

Faith deals with the things not seen. Unlike the senses, faith deals with the revealed truths of God (in His Word), which are both invisible and eternal. It is not based on the evidence of our physical senses but on the eternal, invisible truths and realities revealed in God's Word.

Faith, as opposed to sight, is illustrated in the Scriptures. In Psalm 37:39-40, David did not see first and then believe. He believed first and then he saw. In John 11:39-40, Jesus made it plain that faith consists of believing then seeing, not seeing *first, then* believing. Most people reverse this order, they say: "I will only believe in what I can see", that is, 'to see is to believe'. But this is incorrect. When we actually see a thing, we do not need to exercise our faith on it. It is when we do not see that we are exercising our faith.

D. Conflict between the evidences of our senses and the revelation of God's Word

We may see and feel within our bodies all the evidence of physical sickness. Yet the Bible reveals in Matthew 8:17 that Jesus Himself took our infirmities and bore our sicknesses; and in Isaiah 53:5 with His stripes we are healed. We then have two alternatives:

We may accept the testimony of our senses, thus, accepting the condition of our physical sickness.

or

We may hold firmly to the testimony of God's Word that we are healed. If we do this with persistence/active faith, the testimony of our senses will be brought in line with the testimony of God's Word.

**E. Connection of faith in the heart to confession with the mouth.
(Romans 10:10; Matthew 12:34)**

"When the heart is full, it overflows and pours from the mouth." When our heart is full of faith in Christ, this faith will find its proper expression as we confess Christ openly with our mouth. Faith that is held back in silence without any confession is an incomplete faith that does not bring the resulting blessings we desire (2Corinthians 4:13).

Confession comes from the Greek word *homologin*, meaning, "saying the same as." Confession, then, is saying with our mouths [agreeing with] what God Himself has already said in His Word.

In this sense, the expression of the heart is faith for we naturally speak with our mouths, as we believe in our hearts.

II. WHAT IS THE BASIS OF FAITH?

The basis of having faith in God is in three important realities:

A. The Nature of God (Hebrews 6:13)

- a. He cannot change. (Malachi 3:6; James 1:17)
- b. He cannot fail. (Job 42:2; 1Chronicles 28:20)
- c. He cannot lie. (Numbers 23:19; Titus 1:2)

B. The Redemptive Work of the Son of God (Hebrews 12:2; 1Corinthians 1:30; Romans 5:1,2)

Christ has become the source of our faith in God. The fact of His death and resurrection provides ground for our belief.

C. The Word of God (Matthew 24:35; Isaiah 40:8; Jeremiah 1:12)

His Word stands true forever. Faith comes when God brings a specific word – out of all He has ever said – directly to us in our circumstances. Spoken in this way, the Word of God comes alive to us, releasing our faith.

Source: The Shepherd's Staff By Dr. Ralph Mahoney

III. HOW DOES FAITH WORK?

The principle of faith is to operate in our lives continually, no matter what the circumstances. (Romans 3:27; 2Corinthians 5:7; James 1:5,6)

It works in the following ways:

A. God gives us faith. (Romans 1:17; Habakkuk 2:4)

The righteous live by HIS faith, that is the faith HE gives us as a gift.

B. Faith comes by a Word from God. (Romans 10:17; Genesis 15:3-5, 17:15-21; Joshua 1:8)

God encourages us by speaking a “word” relevant to our circumstances.

C. There must be obedience to the Word. (James 2:17; Genesis 15:6; Matthew 7:24-27)

For faith to operate in our situation, we must obey that word. Faith is *active*, not passive. Most of God’s promises are conditional – He will do His part, if we do our part.

D. Crisis is the ‘trial of our faith.’ (1Peter 1:6,7; Romans 4:16-21; Psalm 105:17-19)

Crisis is a period of testing. Everything happening around us appears contrary to what God has said, and there seems to be no natural evidence for our believing. At this point, our faith rests

completely on God's Word [what He has spoken to us]. In faith we cast ourselves on HIS FAITHFULNESS. In our times of doubt and struggle, God is faithful and does not abandon us.

E. Faith has results.

(James 1:2-4, 12; Genesis 22:1-3; Psalm 105:19-22; Acts 3:16; Hebrews 6:13-15)

The end result of faith is always victory on the part of the believer, bringing glory to God.

Source: The Shepherd's Staff By Dr. Ralph Mahoney